PSCI 3328 - International Relations

Lecture 8 - Levels of Analysis

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PSCI 3328 - Attendance

Introduction

- Deadline: Final Proposal, by Feb. 20 at 11:59pm!
  - Link on eLearning, main points to follow on syllabus
- India won the last activity!
- Debriefing on activity: what did we get about our conversation about power?
- On levels of analysis

Power: Debriefing

What did you get out of the research and discussion on your country?

How did it compare to other sub-groups, and other countries?

Today's Schedule

- Different Levels of Analysis?
- The Levels
- Applications

Different Levels of Analysis?

Different Levels of Analysis?

What do you think we mean by “Levels of Analysis” as part of IR?

Different Levels of Analysis?

Why is Putin attacking Ukraine? He told us.

In a recent speech, the Russian president laid out the nationalist ideas that animate him — and helped cause the Ukraine crisis.

By Zack Beauchamp | @zackbeauchamp | zack@vox.com | Feb 23, 2022, 12:00pm EST

What are Russia's broad interests in Ukraine?

Russia has deep cultural, economic, and political bonds with Ukraine, and in many ways Ukraine is central to Russia's identity and vision for itself in the world.

What really caused the war in Ukraine? Global anarchy — and there's a way to fix it

A truly democratic world federation — which the UN definitely isn't — is the only long-term solution for war

By JANE SHEVTSOV

PUBLISHED JUNE 12, 2022 6:00AM (EDT)

What Caused the War in Ukraine?

- A Simple Question with Many Answers:
  - Was it Putin's personal ambition?
  - Was it the Russian oligarchy or military advisors?
  - Was it the nature of the Russian autocracy?
  - Was it the expansion of NATO and global anarchy?

Different Levels of Analysis?

- The “Level of Analysis” Problem (Singer)
  - *“We have to remember that what we observe is not nature itself, but nature exposed to our method of questioning.”*
  - To find the answer, we must first decide *where* to look.

Different Levels of Analysis?

- **Individual-Level:** explanations focus on the psychology and characteristics of people (usually leaders)
- **Group-Level:** explanation focus on the sociological characteristics of groups
- **State-Level:** explanation focus on characteristics of countries
- **System-Level:** explanation focus on factors across the entire system

Different Levels of Analysis?

Why do levels of analysis matter?

Why it matters

1. Helps to determine where to look for causes
2. Helps to determine where solutions to policy problems might be found, and to keep solutions logically consistent
3. Can help explain phenomena that can't otherwise be explained (helps to refocus)

The Levels

Level 1: The Individual (First Image)

- **Focus:** E.g., the specific characteristics of Vladimir Putin.
- **Waltz's First Image:**
  - War results from selfishness, misdirected aggression, or stupidity.
- Research showing leaders are subject to different kinds of biases and misperceptions, depending on their background (examples?)

Level 2: The Group (Gebhard)

- **Focus:** The “Inner Circle” and Bureaucracy.
- **Gebhard’s Distinction:**
  - The state is not a “unitary actor” but a collection of competing groups.
- Humans behave differently depending on the groups they are in -> different norms, expectations, ways to interact
- <u>What are other group characteristics that might shape group behavior?</u>

Level 3: The State (Second Image)

- **Focus:** explanations rooted in institutions and culture.
- Waltz's Second Image:
  - "Bad states" cause war; "Good states" (democracies?) seek peace.
  - *Application:* Autocratic regimes use war to generate "rally 'round the flag" effects to survive domestically.
- Democratic Peace Theory:
  - no democracy has ever gone to war with another one
  - E.g., A democratic Russia would have found a diplomatic solution? Is the theory plausible?

Level 4: The System (Third Image)

- **Focus:** The Global Environment (The Forest, not the Trees).
- **Waltz's Third Image:**
  - War occurs because there is nothing to prevent it (Anarchy).
  - Usually related to distribution of power (unipolar, bipolar, multipolar...)

System Level: Ideational Structure (Finnemore)

- **Focus:** Norms and Legitimacy.
- **Finnemore's Insight:**
  - The system is defined by *shared ideas* (norms), not just guns and tanks.
- **Clash of Norms:**
  - **Western Norm:** Sovereignty means Ukraine has the right to choose its alliances (NATO).
  - **Russian Norm:** Great Powers have "Spheres of Influence" where they dictate terms.
- **Norm Dynamics:**
  - The war is a contest over which norm will structure the future international order.

System Level: other explanations

- System-wide norm and ideas
- Frequency and intensity of interaction
- Level of resources and technology

How do we know which one to use?

- Look for **falsifiable implications**: if democratic peace theory is true, we should see fewer wars between democracies at the very least
- Look for **special cases** that require additional variables to explain (lots of exceptions = not good)
- Look for **subjugated knowledge** that power considerations may be leading to ignore (e.g. the contention that bipolar systems are more peaceful if we ignore war in the Third World)

So, which level explains the Russia-Ukraine war best?

Summary

- Individual-level explanations say the best way to understand IR is to focus on the characteristics of individuals.
- Group-level explanations focus on how people behave depending on what groups they're in.
- State-level explanations say the best way is to focus on the characteristics of the most important group in the international system: states.
- System-level explanations say the best way to understand international relations is by looking at the biggest possible picture.

Questions?